

Middle Convolution of ℓ -adic Perverse Sheaves

Submitted for Ph.D. Candidacy Examination

Yunhai Xiang

October 8, 2026

Contents

1	Introduction	2
1.1	Notations	2
1.2	Acknowledgements	3
1.3	Motivations	3
2	Local Systems and Lisse Sheaves	5
2.1	Complex Local Systems	5
2.2	ℓ -adic Local Systems	6
2.3	Rigidity of Local Systems	6
3	Perverse Sheaves and Middle Convolution	6
3.1	Six-Functor Formalism	6
3.2	Middle Extension Sheaves	6
3.3	Middle Convolution	6
4	Mod-ℓ Monodromy of Hyperelliptic Curves	6
	Appendix	6
A.1	Analytic Continuation	6
	References	6

1 Introduction

1.1 Notations

1.1.1. Motivated by the growing interest in the formalization of mathematics within the mathematical community, we adopt a style of notation inspired by type theory throughout this report, without committing to type-theoretic foundations. The symbols below denote types and/or categories, depending on your philosophical inclination. The notation $X : T$ means that X is a term of type T or an object of the category T .

Set	Sets
Top	Topological spaces
$\text{Open}(T)$	Open subsets of $T : \text{Top}$
Grp	Groups
Grp^{top}	Topological groups
Grp^{pro}	Profinite groups
Ring	Rings (associative, unital, not necessarily commutative)
Ring^{top}	Topological rings
Field	Fields
$\text{Field}^{\text{top}}$	Topological fields
Mod_R	Left modules over $R : \text{Ring}$
$\text{Mod}_R^{\text{top}}$	Topological left modules over $R : \text{Ring}^{\text{top}}$
Vect_k	Vector spaces over $k : \text{Field}$
$\text{Vect}_k^{\text{fin}}$	Finite-dimensional vector spaces over $k : \text{Field}$
$\text{Rep}_\Lambda(G)$	Continuous Λ -linear representations of $G : \text{Grp}^{\text{top}}$, where $\Lambda : \text{Ring}^{\text{top}}$
$\text{Rep}_\Lambda^{\text{fin}}(G)$	Continuous Λ -linear representations of $G : \text{Grp}^{\text{top}}$, where $\Lambda : \text{Ring}^{\text{top}}$, whose underlying topological Λ -modules are finitely generated
Sch	Schemes
Sch_S	Schemes over a base scheme $S : \text{Sch}$
Var_k	Varieties over $k : \text{Field}$, i.e. integral separated schemes of finite type over k
Curv_k	Curves over $k : \text{Field}$, i.e. one-dimensional varieties over k
$\text{Curv}_k^{\text{sm}}$	Smooth curves over $k : \text{Field}$
$\text{Man}_{\mathbb{C}}$	Complex manifolds
Riem	Riemann surfaces, i.e. connected one-dimensional complex manifolds
Site	Sites, i.e. categories equipped with Grothendieck topologies
$\text{Sh}(X, A)$	Sheaves on $X : \text{Site}$ with values in a category A admitting small limits
$\text{Mod}(X, \mathcal{R})$	Sheaves of left $\mathcal{R}$ -modules on $X : \text{Site}$, where $\mathcal{R} : \text{Sh}(X, \text{Ring})$
$D^b(A)$	Bounded derived objects of an abelian category A
$D^b(X, k)$	Bounded derived objects of $\text{Sh}(X, \text{Vect}_k)$, where $X : \text{Site}$ and $k : \text{Field}$
$X \rightarrow Y$	Morphisms from $X : T$ to $Y : T$

1.2 Acknowledgements

1.2.1. The author thanks his advisor, Prof. Chris Hall, for his guidance and advice.

1.2.2 Typesetting. The typesetting style of this report is inspired by [Kat88].

1.2.3 Declaration of AI Use. The use of generative AI in the preparation of this report was limited to the following purposes: proofreading; polishing wording, phrasing, grammar, and formatting; offering writing advices; answering mathematical questions from the author to help him learn the subject; searching for and citing appropriate references; translating reading materials in French into English; retypesetting old references with archaic typesetting for ease of reading; providing emotional support for the author; providing fitness advice to help the author stay healthy and energetic while working on the report.

1.3 Motivations

1.3.1. *Monodromy groups* are interesting mathematical objects that arise naturally in both geometric and arithmetic contexts. Roughly speaking, they describe how locally defined data change when transported along a loop. Controlling and understanding monodromy groups has been a central theme in both of these worlds, with significant applications.

1.3.2. The goal of this report is to provide an exposition on monodromy groups as well as ways to study them using methods from perverse sheaves and their middle convolution introduced by Katz [Kat96], especially in the ℓ -adic arithmetic context.

1.3.3. Consider the equation

$$z(u)^2 = u \tag{1.3.3.1}$$

for the unknown holomorphic function $z : V \rightarrow \mathbb{C}^\times$, where $V : \text{Open}(\mathbb{C}^\times)$ and $u : V$ is the independent variable. Fix a base point $u_0 : \mathbb{C}^\times$ and choose $z_0 : \mathbb{C}^\times$ with $z_0^2 = u_0$. On a sufficiently small disc V containing u_0 , the equation has two holomorphic solution branches $z_+(u) = \sqrt{u}$ and $z_-(u) = -\sqrt{u}$ with $z_+(u_0) = z_0$ and $z_-(u_0) = -z_0$. Move u once around 0 along the loop

$$\gamma : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{C}^\times, \quad t \mapsto u_0 e^{2\pi i t}.$$

Along this loop, the values of the two solution branches vary continuously as $\tilde{\gamma}_+(t) = z_0 e^{\pi i t}$ and $\tilde{\gamma}_-(t) = -z_0 e^{\pi i t}$, until they eventually swap places at $t = 1$. In other words, there is a permutation representation of the fundamental group¹ $\pi_1^{\text{top}}(\mathbb{C}^\times, u_0) \cong \mathbb{Z} : \text{Grp}^{\text{top}}$

$$\rho : \pi_1^{\text{top}}(\mathbb{C}^\times, u_0) \rightarrow \text{Aut}_{\text{Set}}(\{[z_+]_{u_0}, [z_-]_{u_0}\}), \quad n \mapsto ([z_+]_{u_0} [z_-]_{u_0})^n.$$

We call this representation the *permutation monodromy representation*, and we call its image, isomorphic to S_2 , the *permutation monodromy group*, of the equation (1.3.3.1) at u_0 .

1.3.4. We reformulate the above with sheaves. Consider the covering

$$f : \mathbb{C}^\times \rightarrow \mathbb{C}^\times, \quad \zeta \mapsto \zeta^2.$$

¹with the discrete topology

Let $\mathcal{F} : \text{Sh}(\mathbb{C}^\times, \text{Set})$ be its sheaf of holomorphic sections. Equivalently, this is the sheaf of solutions to the equation (1.3.3.1),

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{F}(V) &= \{z : V \rightarrow \mathbb{C}^\times \mid z \text{ holomorphic and } (f \circ z)|^V = \text{id}_V\} \\ &= \{z : V \rightarrow \mathbb{C}^\times \mid z \text{ holomorphic and } z(u)^2 = u \text{ for every } u : V\}.\end{aligned}$$

As in 1.3.3, on a sufficiently small disc V containing u_0 , the sections are precisely the two holomorphic solution branches z_+ and z_- , identifying

$$\mathcal{F}|_V \cong \underline{\{+, -\}}_V.$$

Hence $\mathcal{F}$ is locally constant, with stalk at u_0

$$\mathcal{F}_{u_0} = \{[z_+]_{u_0}, [z_-]_{u_0}\} \cong f^{-1}(u_0)$$

identified by evaluation. However, the sheaf is not constant: $\mathcal{F}(\mathbb{C}^\times) = \emptyset$. A global section would determine a germ at u_0 fixed by all monodromy at u_0 , whereas transport once around 0 exchanges the two square-root germs, as demonstrated in 1.3.3. Locally constant (but not necessarily constant) sheaves of sets, such as this one, are known as *local systems of sets*.

1.3.5. For a path $\gamma : [0, 1] \rightarrow \mathbb{C}^\times$ from $u_0 = \gamma(0)$ to $u_1 = \gamma(1)$ and a point $\zeta : f^{-1}(u_0)$ in the fibre, let $\tilde{\gamma}_\zeta$ be the unique lift through f satisfying $\tilde{\gamma}_\zeta(0) = \zeta$. We have the *transport map*

$$T_\gamma : \mathcal{F}_{u_0} \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}_{u_1}, \quad \zeta \mapsto \tilde{\gamma}_\zeta(1).$$

with the evaluation identifications $\mathcal{F}_u \cong f^{-1}(u)$. Thus we obtain a *transport functor*²

$$T : \Pi_1(\mathbb{C}^\times) \longrightarrow \text{Set}, \quad u \longmapsto \mathcal{F}_u, \quad [\gamma] \longmapsto T_\gamma.$$

Restricting transport to loops at u_0 gives the same monodromy representation of $\mathcal{F}$ at u_0 as in 1.3.3

$$\rho : \pi_1^{\text{top}}(\mathbb{C}^\times, u_0) \rightarrow \text{Aut}_{\text{Set}}(\mathcal{F}_{u_0}), \quad [\gamma] \mapsto T_\gamma.$$

1.3.6. In § 2, we will see how to upgrade permutation monodromy representations into linear monodromy representations, which we will just call monodromy representations. Moreover, one can use this machinery to talk about monodromy in the ℓ -adic arithmetic context, by replacing π_1^{top} with the étale fundamental group $\pi_1^{\text{ét}}$. When $U = \text{Spec}(k)$ for some $k : \text{Field}$, with a choice of separable closure k^{sep} , then $\pi_1(U, \overline{u_0}) = \text{Gal}(k^{\text{sep}}/k)$, where $\overline{u_0} = \text{Spec}(k^{\text{sep}})$, is the absolute Galois group of k . Hence, a monodromy representation at $\overline{u_0}$ in this case degenerates into a Galois representation, a ubiquitous arithmetic object.

²Here $\Pi_1(X)$ denotes the fundamental groupoid of some $X : \text{Top}$, that is, a category whose objects are points of X and whose morphisms are homotopy classes of paths relative to their endpoints, with concatenation as composition.

2 Local Systems and Lisse Sheaves

2.1 Complex Local Systems

2.1.1. We have looked at permutation monodromy, but permutation actions do not capture all the situations we wish to study, since a lot of times in nature we encounter actions on vector spaces instead of sets. For example, instead of an algebraic equation like the one in 1.3.3, we consider a differential equation, which is known as *Gauss's hypergeometric equation*

$$u(1-u) \frac{d^2 f}{du^2} + (c - (a+b+1)u) \frac{df}{du} - abf = 0 \quad (2.1.1.1)$$

where $a, b, c : \mathbb{C}$ are fixed parameters and $f : V \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$ is an unknown holomorphic function, with $V : \text{Open}(U)$, $U = \mathbb{P}^1(\mathbb{C}) \setminus \{0, 1, \infty\}$, and independent variable $u : V$. We then define the sheaf of solutions to this equation $\mathcal{F} : \text{Sh}(U, \text{Vect}_{\mathbb{C}})$

$$\mathcal{F}(V) = \{f : V \rightarrow \mathbb{C} \mid f \text{ holomorphic and satisfies (2.1.1.1) on } V\}.$$

This is a sheaf of vector spaces since (2.1.1.1) is a homogeneous linear differential equation. For each $u_0 : U$, the existence-and-uniqueness theorem [HTT08, Theorem 4.3.1] gives a sufficiently small open disc $V : \text{Open}(U)$ containing u_0 and an isomorphism of sheaves

$$\mathcal{F}|_V \xrightarrow{\sim} \underline{\mathbb{C}}_V^2$$

Thus $\mathcal{F}$ is locally constant of rank 2. We call such a sheaf a *complex local system of rank 2*.

2.1.2 Definition. (Complex Local System) Let $U : \text{Man}_{\mathbb{C}}$ be connected. A *complex local system* on U is a locally constant sheaf $\mathcal{F} : \text{Sh}(U, \text{Vect}_{\mathbb{C}})$ with finite-dimensional stalks. Explicitly, every $u : U$ has an open neighbourhood $V : \text{Open}(U)$ and an isomorphism

$$\varphi_V : \mathcal{F}|_V \xrightarrow{\sim} \underline{\mathbb{C}}_V^n$$

called a *local trivialization* at u , for some $n : \mathbb{N}$ called the *rank* of $\mathcal{F}$.

2.1.3 Definition. (Transport) Let $\mathcal{F}$ be a complex local system of rank n on a connected $U : \text{Man}_{\mathbb{C}}$. We define the *transport functor*

$$T : \Pi_1(U) \rightarrow \text{Vect}_{\mathbb{C}}^{\text{fin}}, \quad u \mapsto \mathcal{F}_u, \quad [\gamma] \mapsto T_{\gamma}.$$

where the *transport map* $T_{\gamma} : \mathcal{F}_{\gamma(0)} \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}_{\gamma(1)}$ for a path $\gamma : [0, 1] \rightarrow U$ is defined as follows. By compactness of closed intervals, we can choose a subdivision $0 = t_0 < \dots < t_N = 1$ and open sets $V_i : \text{Open}(U)$ containing $\gamma([t_{i-1}, t_i])$, with local trivializations

$$\varphi_i : \mathcal{F}|_{V_i} \xrightarrow{\sim} \underline{\mathbb{C}}_{V_i}^n.$$

Put $v_i = \gamma(t_i)$ for each $i = 0, \dots, N$, then the trivializations induce stalk isomorphisms $\varphi_{i, v_i} : \mathcal{F}_{v_i} \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathbb{C}^n$. The transport map along γ is then defined as the composite

$$T_{\gamma} = (\varphi_{N, v_N}^{-1} \circ \varphi_{N, v_{N-1}}) \circ \dots \circ (\varphi_{1, v_1}^{-1} \circ \varphi_{1, v_0}) : \mathcal{F}_{\gamma(0)} \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathcal{F}_{\gamma(1)}.$$

which is independent of the subdivision and trivializations and depends only on the homotopy class of γ relative to its endpoints, by monodromy theorem [Sch11, Lemma 7.2.7].

2.1.4 Definition. (Monodromy) Let $\mathcal{F}$ be a complex local system of rank n on a connected $U : \text{Man}_{\mathbb{C}}$, and fix a base point $u_0 : U$. Restricting its transport functor to loops at u_0 gives the *monodromy representation* of $\mathcal{F}$ at u_0

$$\rho : \pi_1^{\text{top}}(U, u_0) \rightarrow \text{Aut}_{\text{Vect}_{\mathbb{C}}}(\mathcal{F}_{u_0}), \quad [\gamma] \mapsto T_{\gamma},$$

whose image is the *monodromy group* of $\mathcal{F}$ at u_0 .

2.1.5. Like in 1.3.4, $\mathcal{F}$ is also a sheaf of sections of a cover.

2.1.6 Notation. We use the following notation:

$X : \text{Curv}_{\mathbb{C}}^{\text{sm}}$	A smooth projective connected curve over $\mathbb{C}$
$S : \text{Set}^{\text{fin}}$	A finite nonempty subset of closed points of X
$U : \text{Curv}_{\mathbb{C}}^{\text{sm}}$	The open subvariety $X \setminus S$
$j : U \rightarrow X$	The inclusion map
$m : \mathbb{N}$	The cardinality of S
$(-)^{\text{an}} : \text{Curv}_{\mathbb{C}}^{\text{sm}} \rightarrow \text{Riem}$	The complex analytification functor

2.2 ℓ -adic Local Systems

2.3 Rigidity of Local Systems

3 Perverse Sheaves and Middle Convolution

3.1 Six-Functor Formalism

3.2 Middle Extension Sheaves

3.3 Middle Convolution

4 Mod- ℓ Monodromy of Hyperelliptic Curves

Appendix

A.1 Analytic Continuation

A.1.1. Definition of Analytic Continuation.

References

- [HTT08] Ryoshi Hotta, Kiyoshi Takeuchi, and Toshiyuki Tanisaki. *D-Modules, Perverse Sheaves, and Representation Theory*, volume 236 of *Progress in Mathematics*. Birkhäuser, 2008.

- [Kat88] Nicholas M. Katz. *Gauss Sums, Kloosterman Sums, and Monodromy Groups*, volume 116 of *Annals of Mathematics Studies*. Princeton University Press, 1988.
- [Kat96] Nicholas M. Katz. *Rigid Local Systems*, volume 139 of *Annals of Mathematics Studies*. Princeton University Press, 1996.
- [Sch11] Pierre Schapira. Algebra and topology. Lecture notes, course at Paris VI University, 2007–2008, version 2, 2011. https://www.math.univ-paris13.fr/~ginot/AT/Schapira_Notes_AlTo.pdf.